

News Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **news story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 1,260 students enrolled in grades 9-12. In the fall semester, the school faced three major plumbing incidents where toilets overflowed, each resulting in a set of boys and girls bathrooms being closed until further notice. When students returned from winter break, one restroom remained open, with the exception of athletic facilities. The open bathroom has a side for girls and a side for boys, each with six stalls. The open bathroom is at the east end of the building.

Last week, Principal Lydia Deetz announced that in addition to removing and replacing multiple toilet and sink fixtures, the school would need to replace one of the central sewer lines after hours, which will cost the district more than \$200,000. She also said when diagnosing the issue, plumbers found several dozen discarded vaping components in drains and sewer lines within the school, leading them to believe this was the cause of the multiple blockages in the school bathrooms.

The school will be closed Jan. 15-16 while workers repair the damaged bathrooms and sewer lines. You are writing for the issue of the press to be distributed Jan. 9.

■ **LYDIA DEETZ, principal**

“This district is operating in a \$12 million budget deficit. We cut staff positions and even closed the early childhood center in the spring. The district has funds budgeted for unforeseen maintenance problems but not a lot. Our district simply can’t afford these types of issues right now.

“We need parents and students to get on board with us on the vaping issue. Students caught vaping at school or at school events receive a mandatory placement at the district’s Disciplinary Alternative Education Program campus. That’s something that’s mandated by the state. So, when a student gets caught vaping in a bathroom, which is a daily occurrence, they typically toss the evidence in the toilet to avoid their DAEP placement. That appears to be the biggest cause of these overflowed toilets.

“Forget the fact that vaping is one of the worst things you can do to your body. Forget that it makes the building smell terrible. Forget that it could get you sent to alternative school. The vaping in the bathrooms has now put our district in a major financial hardship. The superintendent has tasked us with putting an end to the constant vaping issues — yes, because we care about our students, but also because we just can’t afford to do this anymore. For this reason, we intend to begin working with campus police in investigating vaping incidents as acts of vandalism. This could lead to a criminal mischief charge, which is not something students want on their records.”

■ LELAINA PIERCE, senior

“One day, I walked into the downstairs west bathroom, and as soon as I walked in, I could feel the cold water topping over my flip flops. I knew it was dirty toilet water, and I immediately knew why. There’s someone vaping in that bathroom almost every time I go in. It’s disgusting. Because of other people’s stupid habits, not only did I have my feet covered in sewage water in the middle of the school day, but now there’s also only one working bathroom for more than 1,000 students. If I’m on the west side of campus, it takes at least 10 minutes for me to walk out to the main hallway and get all the way to the east bathrooms. And there’s always a line waiting. It takes about half the class period just to go to the bathroom. They’re even paying a sub to sit there and monitor like we’re prisoners. I wish some of my classmates would take a little more personal responsibility and try to make it through the school day without vaping. It can’t be that hard.”

■ SAWYER ERICKSON, city council member

“Student vaping is an issue that seems to cause more problems every year. We’ve met with district administrators to see how we can best support them in their mission to keep students safe and healthy. One of the things we’re looking at is how many vape shops are actually located close to campus. We’re looking at a change to our zoning ordinances that would prevent those businesses from being anywhere near a school. We’re going to partner with our schools and do anything we can to support them.”

■ JOE MARTSCH, freshman

“I can’t get to class on time as it is, and I can’t afford any more tardies. The school is so big. You almost need an off period in your schedule to be able to use the restroom. I’m even thinking of joining track this spring, so I can have access to the bathrooms in the locker room. That’s how desperate things are getting.”

■ VERONICA RYDER, parent

“I was shocked to hear the price tag for a plumbing repair. The district has asked repeatedly for parent support on this vaping issue. As a parent and a taxpayer in the district, I highly encourage all my fellow parents to talk with your children about the potential consequences of vaping. It isn’t just hurting the person doing the vaping anymore. It’s costing us big-time, and I’m glad the district is finally doing something to seek justice. The students causing this damage can’t keep getting away with it.”

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

Invitational A Meet • 2026 News Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Open with the most timely lead, given the current circumstances, probably the future event or events. In this instance, the story will be published before the school closes for two days to repair damage caused by students discarding vapes in school bathrooms.

The campus will close for repairs Jan. 15 and 16 after plumbers found damaged sewer lines. According to plumbers, discarded vape cartridges caused most of the damage, which will cost the school over \$200,000.

2. Use direct quotes and use those quotes early in the story. Start with the most important interview to the story. After you introduce quotes, use the transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute the quote. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Deetz said." not "said Deetz.") Avoid putting two or more quotes from different people together without placing a transition between them (stacking quotes). Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the story flow, and that the quote does not repeat information revealed in the transition.

transition

Principal Lydia Deetz said she is looking into charging students with vandalism for discarding their vapes in a way that causes damage to school property.

direct quote

"Forget the fact that vaping is one of the worst things you can do to your body," she said. "Forget that it makes the building smell terrible. Forget that it could get you sent to alternative school. The vaping in the bathrooms has now put our district in a major financial hardship."

transition

The district is currently operating in a \$12 million budget deficit and does not have money budgeted to complete the major repairs beyond general maintenance.

direct quote

“Our district simply can’t afford these types of issues right now,” Deetz said.
“We need parents and students to get on board with us on the vaping issue.”

3. Use third person. Don’t say “our students” or “our principal” or “Some of our students.” Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say “This idea probably won’t work ...” or “The district should ...” without attributing that quote to someone. These statements are personal opinions and cannot be made in a news story.

4. Note how in the earlier example of transition/quote, each quote is its own paragraph. Journalistic writing consists mostly of one- and two-sentence paragraphs.

5. End with a strong quote that wraps up the story.

ending transition/quote

Students caught vaping receive a state-mandated disciplinary school placement, but parent Veronica Ryder said she supports the district’s working with law enforcement to charge students for damage to school property.

“As a parent and a taxpayer in the district, I highly encourage all my fellow parents to talk with your children about the potential consequences of vaping,” she said. “It isn’t just hurting the person doing the vaping anymore. It’s costing us big-time, and I’m glad the district is finally doing something to seek justice.”

SAMPLE STORY

The campus will close for repairs Jan. 15 and 16 after plumbers found damaged sewer lines. According to plumbers, discarded vape cartridges caused most of the damage, which will cost the school more than \$200,000.

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“Forget the fact that vaping is one of the worst things you can do to your body,” she said. “Forget that it makes the building smell terrible. Forget that it could get you sent to alternative school. The vaping in the bathrooms has now put our district in a major financial hardship.”

The district is currently operating in a \$12 million budget deficit and does not have money budgeted to complete the major repairs beyond general maintenance.

“Our district simply can’t afford these types of issues right now,” Deetz said. “We need parents and students to get on board with us on the vaping issue.”

Students’ bathroom options on campus have dwindled as restrooms closed for repairs, with only one restroom remaining open by the end of the fall semester.

“If I’m on the west side of campus, it takes at least 10 minutes for me to walk out to the main hallway and get all the way to the east bathrooms,” senior Lelaina Pierce said. “And there’s always a line waiting outside. It takes about half the class period just to go to the bathroom.”

Pierce said the closure for major repairs did not come as a surprise.

“One day, I walked into the downstairs west bathroom, and as soon as I walked in, I could feel the cold water topping over my flip flops,” Pierce said. “I knew it was dirty toilet water, and I immediately knew why. There’s someone vaping in that bathroom almost every time I go in.”

The city has been working with the district to try to alleviate the issue by changing zoning ordinances that would prevent retail stores that sell vapes and vape cartridges from doing business near the school.

“Student vaping is an issue that seems to cause more and more problems every year,” city council member Sawyer Erickson said. “We’re going to partner with our schools and do anything we can to support them.”

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“As a parent and a taxpayer in the district, I highly encourage all my fellow parents to talk with your children about the potential consequences of vaping,” she said. “It isn’t just hurting the person doing the vaping anymore. It’s costing us big-time, and I’m glad the district is finally doing something to seek justice.”